

The Christmas Island blue-tailed skink is back in the wild and being celebrated as a major conservation milestone thanks to years of planning and collaboration involving Parks Australia, Taronga Zoo and the department.

In June 2026, more than 500 Christmas Island blue-tailed skinks were released onto Horsburgh Island in the Cocos (Keeling) Islands, a remarkable achievement since a few dozen were rescued from extinction in 2009-10.

The Christmas Island blue-tailed skink (*Cryptoblepharus egeriae*) as well as the Lister's gecko (*Lepidodactylus listeri*) were both once common across Christmas Island. However, their populations declined rapidly during the 1990s, largely due to predation by the invasive wolf snake (*Lycodon capucinus*).

By 2013, both species had disappeared from the wild and were listed as 'Extinct in the Wild' on the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) Red List of Threatened Species. Before both species vanished, Parks Australia staff undertook a last-chance rescue mission, collecting around 60 blue-tailed skinks and 40 Lister's geckos from Christmas Island.

Those animals became the foundation of a breeding program established on Christmas Island and at Taronga Zoo in Sydney. The breeding program grew to become one of Australia's most significant reptile recovery efforts.

With populations thriving in captivity, attention turned to returning the animals to the wild. Because threats remain on Christmas Island, conservationists identified Horsburgh Island as a safer location for reintroduction. Experts from Parks Australia and Taronga Zoo worked closely with the department to develop the biosecurity policies, permit conditions and procedures needed to support the translocation and successful release of more than 500 blue-tailed skinks.

This release is being celebrated, and it is hoped that one day the blue-tailed skinks Red List status may be reassessed and lowered from 'Extinct in the Wild'. Now, planning is underway for the release of Lister's geckos on the Cocos (Keeling) Islands by 2028.

Image credit: Parks Australia

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/critically-endangered-reptiles-return-wild>